

FROM THE HILLS TO THE SEA
Chef Ana Roš (right) introduced Slovenian cuisine to Indian diners

Imagine stepping into a transformed dining room at The Leela Palace, New Delhi, where every detail—from the music to the table settings—echoes the essence of the three-Michelin-starred Osteria Francescana in Modena. The mastermind behind it, chef patron Massimo Bottura, greets you warmly. The first course arrives: 'The Crunchy Part of the Lasagne', an ode to childhood memories, its texture as bold as its flavour. Later, 'Oops! I Dropped the Lemon Tart' makes a playful appearance. Between bites, Bottura weaves stories of heritage and innovation, creating an experience that transcends food.

This dinner marked Chef Bottura's third visit to India in as many years, highlighting the deep connection he feels with the country. For long, India was a forgotten destination on the global culinary map. Chefs from Michelin-starred restaurants and those ranked on the World's Best lists toured Asian gastronomic hotspots like Hong Kong, Bangkok or Dubai, but not India. However, over the past few years, India has hosted a constellation of culinary titans, transforming its dining landscape into a stage for gastronomic theatre.

Raaj Sanghvi, CEO of Culinary Culture, which has been instrumental in many such collaborations, recalls the early days of this shift. "Since the first events in 2018, we've hosted nearly 100 chefs," he says. "The idea was to create a culinary exchange programme where chefs come to India, experience its diverse cuisines, and take a bit of it back with them, while giving Indian diners the opportunity to experience the work of global culinary legends."

Hotels like Taj Mahal, New Delhi, have been at the forefront of such events. Last February, Chef Ana Roš of the three-Michelin-starred

INTERVIEW

PRIDE OF INDIA

Michelin-starred chef **Garima Arora** *who made waves with Gaa, her modern take on Indian food in Bangkok, comes full circle with Banng, her Thai restaurant in Gurugram*

Q. What drew you to cooking professionally?
Growing up in a Punjabi household, food was a big part of my life. Deep down, I knew I wanted a career in food. Being a chef is a young person's game and couldn't be put off. In 2010, I packed my bags for Paris and graduated from Le Cordon Bleu.

Q. What made you open an Indian restaurant in Bangkok?
Thailand chose me. I was supposed to be there for a short while. One thing led to another, and suddenly I found myself opening a restaurant. I wanted to do Indian food but with a twist—using local Thai ingredients to create something new and exciting.

Q. What is the food philosophy of Gaa?
We want guests to be surprised by the prowess of Indian techniques, ingredients and flavours when they are applied to a new set of ingredients. The result is something new, but still Indian at heart.

Q. How do you balance work and motherhood?
Being a chef is demanding. You have to be present physically and be on your feet. I'm privileged that I have my own business and can carve out my time according to the needs of me and my baby.

Q. And now you have ventured into Thai food with Banng...
Banng feels like the other half of my journey. A



Indian techniques and flavours are applied to a new set of ingredients in **GAA**, Garima Arora's Bangkok restaurant